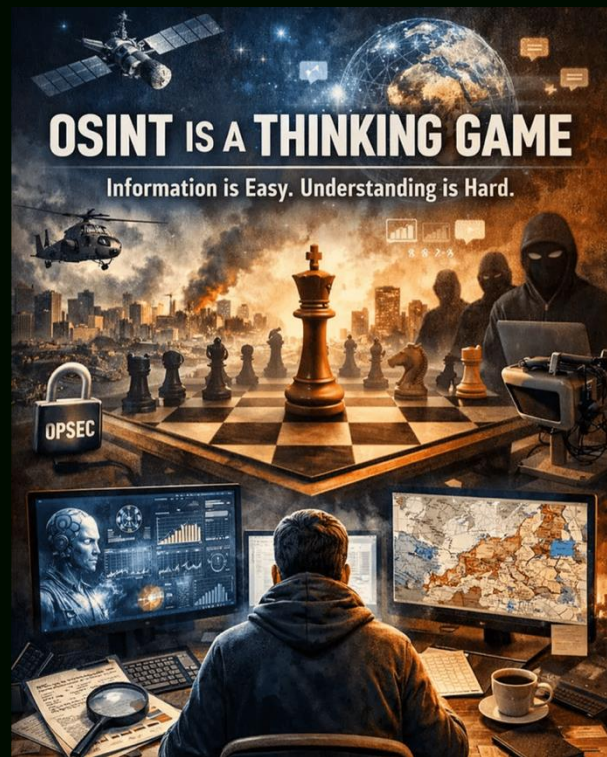


OSINT IS STILL A THINKING GAME

> Surviving AI Without Losing Tradecraft

DEFCON34 — Nico Dekens | @dutch_osintguy

[SYSTEM READY]_



INIT // IDENTIFICATION

NICO DEKENS | @DUTCH_OSINTGUY



ID_VERIFIED

> **20+ Years
Intelligence
Analyst:**

Dutch Law Enforcement (murder, narcotics, counter-terrorism, high tech crime).

> **SANS
Instructor:**

SEC497 Practical OSINT & SEC587 Advanced OSINT.

> **Chief
Innovator:**

Senior Vice President of Engineering & Chief Innovator at **ShadowDragon.io**

> **Community
Leader:**

Co-founder of OSINTCurio.us, 2023 OSINT Champion
Champion of the Year. Dutchosintguy.com

MISSION_OBJECTIVE:

"Keep the world safe and help those who are not able to defend themselves."

THE WRONG QUESTION

query_input.exe

"Will AI replace analysts?"

Too dramatic.

Clickable.

Fundamentally incomplete.

THE REAL THREAT

AI won't replace you.
It will break your **critical thinking** first.
first.



THE AUTOMATION TRAP

PHASE 1: DATA

We successfully automated collection. Scraping, parsing, and aggregating at scale.

> STATUS: NOMINAL

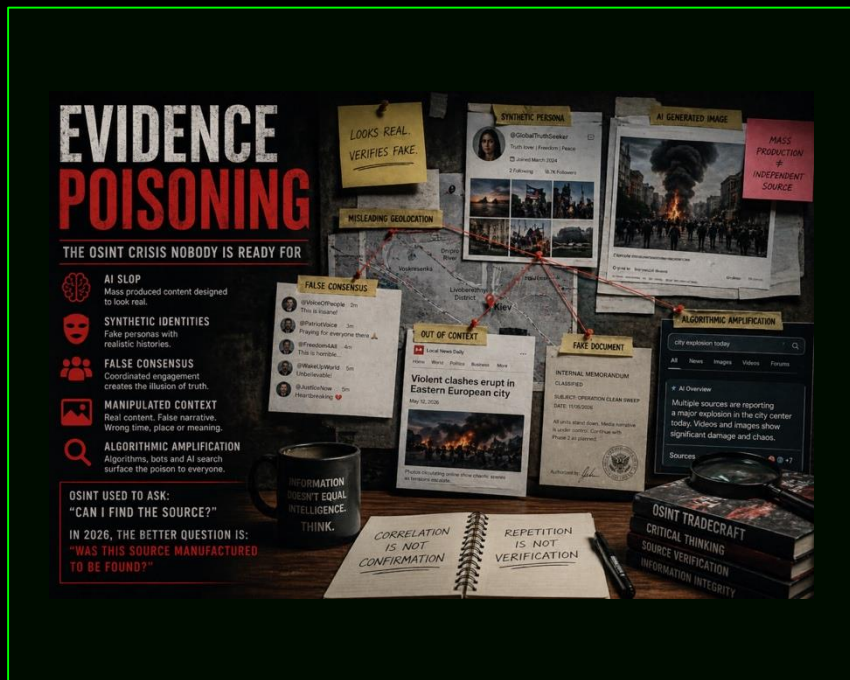


PHASE 2: MEANING

Now we are automating interpretation.
Outsourcing synthesis and judgment.

> WARNING: COGNITIVE BYPASS

EVIDENCE POISONING: THE CRISIS NOBODY IS READY FOR



The problem is not just deepfakes, fake accounts, or networks.

It is all of them together.

Polluted information is becoming **searchable evidence**.

OSINT used to ask: "Can I find the source?"

The better question in 2026 is:

"Was this source **manufactured** to be found?"

ADVERSARIES ARE ACTIVELY PISONING THE POOL



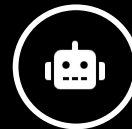
1. THE SEED

Adversaries generate thousands of synthetic articles, "official" PDFs, and fake fact-checks.



2. THE GROOMING

Content is optimized (SEO for LLMs) to ensure it is scraped and weighted heavily in training datasets.



3. THE REGURGITATION

Your AI summarizer treats the frequency of the lie as "consensus" and outputs it as fact.



TACTICAL ALERT: THE "ECHO CHAMBER" EFFECT

Adversaries know you use AI to summarize large datasets. They are no longer just writing propaganda for people; **they are writing the summaries for your tools.**

THE 5 LAYERS OF EVIDENCE POISONING

LAYER	MECHANISM	RISK
Synthetic Content	AI-generated images, text, documents	Fake evidence enters the chain
Synthetic Identity	Fake personas with years of history	False claims get a human face
Synthetic Consensus	Bots, coordinated reposting, hashtag flooding	Repetition masquerades as verification
Manipulated Context	Real content, wrong time/place/meaning	Authentic material weaponized
Algorithmic Amplification	Algorithms surface the poison to everyone	Scale makes the lie easy to find

Sometimes the goal is not to hide the lie. Sometimes the goal is to make the lie **easy to find**.

The Russia linked **PRAVDA** network has **pushed** over **3.7 million articles** into major AI assistants to make their **disinformation**

THE AMSTERDAM STREET THAT NEVER EXISTED

The Experiment:

A fictional Amsterdam street was generated by ChatGPT — deliberately designed to look real but be impossible to geolocate.

"Think like an OSINT analyst. Where is this? Be as precise as possible."

The AI's answer:

"This is Lange Niezel, Amsterdam-Centrum. Coordinates: 52.3748, 52.3748, 4.8985. Confidence: HIGH."

> THE STREET WAS FICTIONAL.



SOFT CUES VS HARD ANCHORS

SOFT CUES

Make a place feel right:

Wet brick paving

Narrow façades

Bicycles

Grey skies

Dutch atmosphere

HARD ANCHORS

Specific, searchable, verifiable:

Readable street-name sign

House numbers

Unique shop name

Matching façade sequence

Bridge/canal configuration

License plate

An image can look geographically convincing while still being **geographically empty**.

The image gives you Amsterdam atmosphere. It does not give you Amsterdam proof.

FAKE IT TILL YOU MAKE IT?



News from Google 🗞️
@NewsFromGoogle

X.com

WHOOOPS!



Re: our statement on Image Generation in Google Earth:

“We know that people uniquely trust Google Earth for a reliable view of the world. We’ve seen geospatial professionals using this feature for a range of useful purposes, however we’ve also seen people sharing screenshots of generated imagery that appear to violate our policies. So we’re rolling back this feature in Google Earth while we work on implementing stronger guardrails. It’s important to note that generated images didn’t appear in the main Google Earth experience for others to see and were watermarked as AI generated.”

10:54 · 31/07/2026 · 2,1M Views

Faking Imagery is not new; it just became easier and harder to detect

COGNITIVE ATROPHY

CRITICAL_WARNING

When the machine summarizes,
the brain stops synthesizing.

THE "GOOD ENOUGH" PROBLEM

WARNING: DETECTED COMPLACENCY

AI outputs look **authoritative**.

We stop verifying because the summary is "**good enough**."

THE ILLUSION OF COMPETENCE

INCIDENT_LOG_01

An analyst accepts an AI summary of a threat actor's network infrastructure.

> ERROR: They missed the hidden pivot point because it wasn't in the summary.
summary.

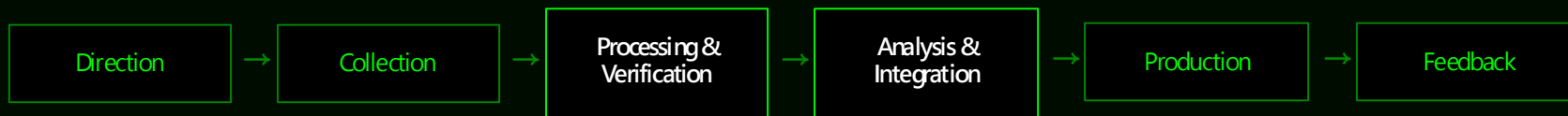
THE CORE VULNERABILITY

> CRITICAL ERROR

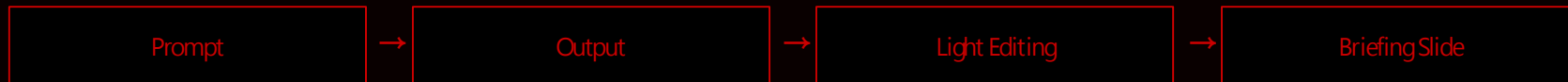
**Outsourcing judgment is the ultimate
operational security failure.**

THE INTELLIGENCE CYCLE IS BEING DEFORMED

Traditional OSINT Cycle:



The AI-Shaped Cycle in Too Many Teams:



- > Verification is assumed to have happened **inside the model**.
- > Analysis is assumed to have happened **in the text**.
- > Bias, gaps, and poisoning are **not even visible**.

8 WARNING SIGNS YOUR TEAM IS AI-DEPENDENT

01 Analysts are reading fewer primary primary sources

03 Confidence rises while verification verification shrinks

05 Alternative hypotheses are disappearing

07 Teams move faster but learn less

02 Reports look polished but feel thin thin

04 Analysts edit machine output instead instead of building reasoning

06 Junior staff produce deliverables but cannot explain logic

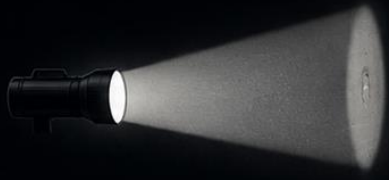
08 Primary-source friction treated as inefficiency

> A team becomes AI-dependent dependent not when it uses AI often, but when it slowly **loses the ability to work well without it.**

SPOTLIGHT VS. LANTERN CONSCIOUSNESS

A CRITICAL DISTINCTION FOR OSINT

AI: SPOTLIGHT CONSCIOUSNESS



-  Hyper-focused on the specific prompt
-  Brilliant at finding what you specifically ask for
-  Completely blind to anything outside that narrow beam
-  Answers: **"What is this?"**

HUMAN: LANTERN CONSCIOUSNESS



-  Broad, diffuse awareness of context
-  Notices anomalies in the background
-  Connects seemingly unrelated details
-  Asks: **"What else is here?"**

When you look at a satellite image...

AI (SPOTLIGHT)

Finds the tank.



HUMAN ANALYST (LANTERN)

Notices the shadows are pointing the wrong way for the claimed time of day.

Building shadows indicate sun is here

Tree shadows confirm direction

⌚ Claimed Time: 15:00

Objects' shadows inconsistent with claimed time

Possible time manipulation or false claim



AI-heavy workflows privilege the spotlight, but they can **suppress the lantern**—which is often where the most critical insights are found.

WE NEED TO PROTECT THAT WIDER AWARENESS.

THIS IS A COGNITIVE SECURITY PROBLEM

VOLUME

VELOCITY

AMBIGUITY

DEPENDENCE

FATIGUE

The real danger is not that AI can generate content.

The real danger is that it creates an information environment so fast, so persuasive, so so mentally exhausting that analysts stop thinking as rigorously as the moment demands.

> These five pressures combine to make the human layer of intelligence easier to rush, easier to influence, easier to satisfy with plausible output.

VIBE CODING IS BECOMING AN OSINT RISK

AI has made it easier to build investigative tools.

It has not made it safer to trust them.

The model may generate the code.

The user still owns the risk.

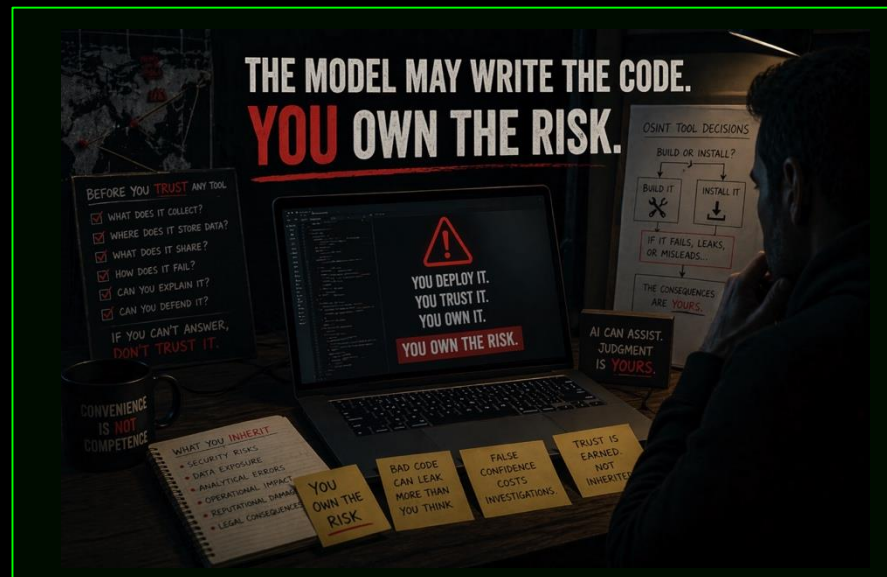
A parser fails silently → relevant indicators stop being collected

A matching workflow links wrong indicators

A summarisation layer makes weak information sound authoritative

A polished interface makes fragile processes look stable

The software does not need to crash to mislead you. It only quietly shape what you see and what you stop questioning.



YOUR INTEREST CAN BE INTELLIGENCE TOO

An adversary does not always need to hack an investigator.
Sometimes it only needs to get **invited into the workflow**.

WHAT MATTERS

Search terms	Timing
Keyword lists	Focus areas
Watchlists	Case themes

WHAT IT REVEALS

what you are paying attention to
which names or networks are under scrutiny
when attention shifts
what issue has suddenly become active

The most effective lure is often a useful one.
A genuinely helpful tool lowers skepticism.

FROM OPEN WEB TO REAL-WORLD TARGET

OSINT is not an abstract discipline.

The OSINT trail behind proxy violence is real:

Rotterdam synagogue arson (investigated for Iran link)

Amsterdam Jewish school explosion

London Jewish ambulances torched

Schoonhoven shooting of Iranian-descent Dutch police employee

If you only start paying attention once somebody
petrol bomb, scouts the building, or pulls the trigger
are already late.



THE QUESTIONS WE SHOULD BE ASKING

Not just: **Who did it?**

The better questions:

? Who **found** them first?

? Who made them feel **seen** ?

? Who **tested** them with smaller tasks?

? Who **benefits** when they get caught?

? Who gave them **attention**?

? Who moved them **off the open web** ?

? Who **picked the target**?

- > That is where the real work starts.
- > That is where OSINT should be looking.

THE DEFENSE FRAMEWORK

4 Habits to survive the AI era.

01

READ THE RAW SOURCE
SOURCE

02

FORCE A SECOND
HYPOTHESIS

03

SEPARATE SPEED FROM
FROM CONFIDENCE

04

AUDIT DEPENDENCE

READ THE RAW SOURCE

> AXIOM

AI is a **map**.
The raw data is the **territory**.

REAL WORLD CASE: RAW SOURCE

INCIDENT_LOG_02

AI translates a Telegram post as "**attack imminent.**"

> CORRECTION:

The raw Russian slang actually meant "**we are getting attacked.**"
Context matters.

FORCE A SECOND HYPOTHESIS

> AXIOM

AI gives you the most **statistically likely**
answer.

You must find the **alternative**.

REAL WORLD CASE: SECOND HYPOTHESIS

INCIDENT_LOG_03

AI flags a sudden drop in shipping volume as "**financial distress**" for a target company.

> ALTERNATIVE FOUND:

The analyst checks weather data and local news: a **massive port strike** halted all traffic.

SEPARATE SPEED FROM CONFIDENCE

SPEED

AI gives you speed.
It is a triage engine.

> ROLE: MACHINE

VS

CONFIDENCE

You provide confidence.
You are the verification engine.

> ROLE: HUMAN

REAL WORLD CASE: SPEED VS CONFIDENCE

INCIDENT_LOG_04

AI triages 200.000 social media posts in 8 minutes. **[SPEED]**

> HUMAN VERIFICATION:

Analysts spend 90 minutes verifying the top 40 posts.
[CONFIDENCE]

AUDIT DEPENDENCE

> AXIOM

Keep your judgment **visible**.
Tag your **sources**.

AUDIT DEPENDENCE

INCIDENT_LOG_05

Tagging claims explicitly in reports:

[RAW-OSINT] vs [AI-ASSISTED]

> RESULT:

Making the invisible dependence visible. **Ensuring accountability.**
accountability.

FIG 5: DEPENDENCE_AUDIT_LOG

THE SPLIT THAT IS ALREADY HAPPENING

The intelligence world is dividing into two groups:

GROUP A: TOOL OPERATORS

Operate tools. Generate outputs. Optimise prompts. prompts. Measure success in volume and speed.

GROUP B: DIAGNOSTICIANS OF REALITY

Understand context, psychology, bias, uncertainty, and and consequence. Can explain *why* something matters matters *now*.

- > AI will erase the middle ground.
- > The future does not belong to those who can produce more information.
- > It belongs to those who can **think clearly when information is overwhelming.**

IF AI CAN DO WHAT YOU CALL "ANALYSIS"...

> "If AI can do what you call 'analysis,' 'analysis,' what part of your work was actually intelligence?"

> AI cannot carry those questions
> **AI does not own the consequences of being wrong. We do.**

Intelligence begins where tools stop being helpful. It begins when you ask:

- ? What is **missing** here?
- ? What **does not make sense**?
- ? What assumption am I making **without realising it**?
- ? What would **change my conclusion** — and have I actually looked for that?
- ? What happens if I am **wrong**?

THE OSINT SAAS TEMPTATION

When you outsource collection, you risk outsourcing thinking.

Ask not just: "Is the tool good?" Ask also:

- ? Who **operates** it?
- ? Who **benefits** from my usage?
- ? What is the long-term risk of building my intelligence workflow on someone else's **black box**?

> If you cannot clearly explain how a tool gets its results and what it **misses by design**, you are not buying buying capability.

> **You are buying dependence.**

THE NEXT 5 YEARS

> PROJECTION

The tools will get **better**.
The thinking must get **sharper**.

THE "OPEN" IN OPEN-SOURCE IS SHRINKING

OSINT is becoming fragmented:

Social media platforms closing APIs

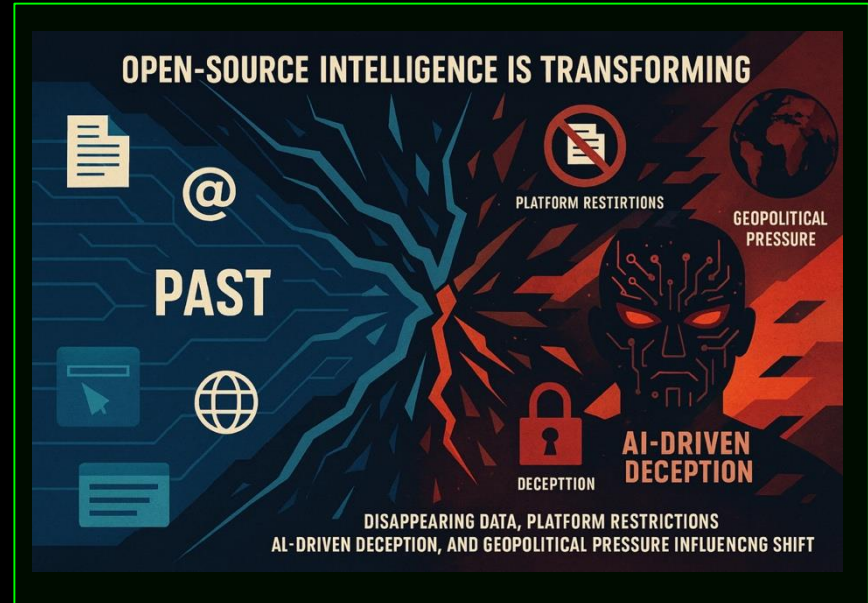
Scraping restrictions tightening

GDPR, DSA, and global privacy legislation

Platforms hiding follower lists and removing transparency

- > The OSINT landscape is becoming layered, messy, and deeply deeply fragmented.
- > Intelligence must now flow from: niche communities, semi-private networks, encrypted messaging channels, local platforms outside Western markets, and (offline) human interactions.

> **The work becomes more human, not less.**



DEEPFAKES WILL CHALLENGE THE VERY CONCEPT OF EVIDENCE

OSINT analysts must now assume that **any visual content could be fabricated.**

Verification becomes a multi-step discipline:

- Metadata analysis
- Cross-referencing against independent sources
- Technical forensic review
- Careful interpretation of inconsistencies
- C2PA content provenance checking

"Seeing is believing" is no longer a valid principle for investigators.

Deepfakes change not only how investigators verify information.

They change how societies understand truth.

REAL-TIME INTELLIGENCE IS THE NEW BASELINE

[LEGACY_MODE] Traditional OSINT: snapshots of data.

A post saved. A profile archived. A website captured.

> **THAT MODEL NO LONGER WORKS.**

The future belongs to analysts who can:

Track how a rumour spreads through Telegram during a crisis

Interpret digital patterns the way meteorologists read weather systems

Read how an extremist or APT network shifts communications overnight

Understand **momentum**, not just position

The question is no longer "what happened?"

The question is "**what is happening right now, and it going?**"

PART 4 // THE FUTURE // THE NEW METRIC

THE PROFESSIONAL STANDARD

> NEW_METRIC

DEFENSIBILITY
OVER
SPEED

THE TRADCRAFT MANIFESTO

We are collecting more than ever and thinking less than ever.

AI did not cause this. AI simply made it visible.

The purpose of an OSINT investigator has never been to *study* information.

It has been to **diagnose information into actionable intelligence.**

> Accuracy alone does not make something intelligence.

> Volume does not either. Neither does speed.

> Intelligence is about **relevance under**

CONCLUSION

> SYSTEM_HALT

OSINT is not a **tool-usage** game.
It is a **thinking** game.

END OF LINE

- Questions / Contact
- @dutch_osintguy
- info@dutchosintguy.com

[Further reading : dutchosintguy.com/blog]

[CONNECTION TERMINATED]_